

Key drivers of growth

The demand for professionals in this field is rising for two reasons:

1. Increasingly data is being stored outside the organisation
2. Internal data theft

There has been a steady rise in cyber attacks (28 per cent in the first six months of 2002). According to a survey in 2001, cyber attacks cost businesses roughly \$13.2 billion in damage and clean-up costs while in the preceding year, it was \$17.1 billion. Some institutions were even forced to shut down their entire networks to fix the problem.

In response to this, organisations and governments are gearing up to take necessary preventive and remedial measures. India has recognised cyber crime and necessary security actions are being taken on the government and personal level. As social and government awareness about cyber security increases, job opportunities for computer forensic and security experts will also increase. As state governments are opening cyber crime departments, this will also bring more job openings.

Rakesh Goyal, is the founder of Sysman India, a cyber security firm. He has been in the industry since 1991. He tackles some of our questions:

Why did you choose this career?

Rakesh Goyal, founder, Sysman India: Serendipity chose my career for me. I did my first forensics assignment by chance in 1991 and for free. That's when I realised that I have natural inclination towards IT forensics. It led to writing a book in 1993. Gradually, it became IT security over a period of time. In 2004, when IS security consulting became a lucrative business, software businesses were closed and efforts were diverted towards the IT security business.

Every case is unique and a challenge. No two cases / assignments are the same. So, it is a delight for any challenge-loving person. One gets to apply all the faculties at his or her command to secure the assets or investigate the case. In investigations, the person must think laterally like Sherlock Holmes.

What are the required skill sets?

Rakesh Goyal: A number of colleges and short-term courses have been launched which train a person on different aspects of computer security and forensics.

Based on the performance in exams and prior experience, certifications like CISA, CISM, CISSP are awarded. These certificates are recognised by the industry. No minimum qualification is required to appear for these exams.

For entry in the profession, one just needs an IT background with understanding of C++ and JAVA and preferably, knowledge of the law and business processes.

Required mind set

The most important ingredient for success is the mindset. To succeed, one needs to be a nit-picker and be able to think like a criminal.

One should be a constant learner as there is a need to update skills and knowledge on

an hourly basis. For a person who is averse to reading / studying (and has cleared exams with keys / cramming), this is not the field to make a career in. It's a low profile job. One cannot talk to the press about an assignment; not even reveal a client's identity.